COACHING MODULE



SELBORNE COLLEGE RUGBY CLUB

Module 9: **Power up the brain and get into the zone**
Multiple Intelligences
Mind over matter
Thinking like a champion
Rugby brain profile

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POWER UP THE BRAIN AND GET INTO THE ZONE:

We're hard wired at birth to react to stress in certain physical ways. Now our ancient instincts, honed over millennia to survive the attack of a sabre-toothed tiger or fight off raiders from another tribe, could be managed to produce better rugby players according to Colquhoun, A. (2007). We are born with an unlimited amount of brain potential. The main functions of the brain are thinking, learning and creativity. "This makes brain power the number one determiner for success" Rugby News Annual (2005). The sports person who has the ability to out-think, out-wit, out-learn, out-create and out-play the competition will have a definite advantage.

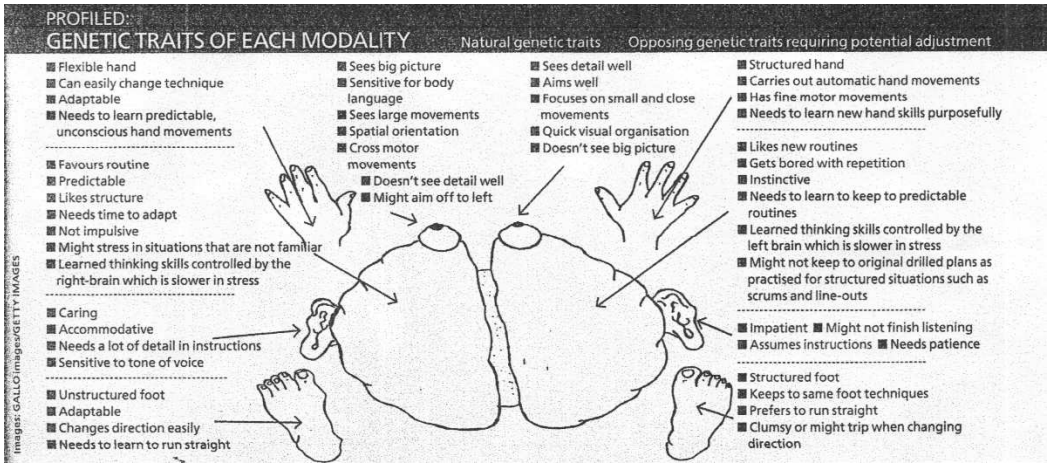
Brain Fitness:
We are all born with two brain hemispheres, but we don't automatically use both of them. This is referred to as **homolateral**, which means we only utilise one hemisphere of the brain at a time in alternating fashion. Homolaterality slows people's learning, thinking and creative capacity down, resulting in them being more frustrated, having to work longer and harder, rather than faster and smarter according to Vermeulen, A. (2005). Utilising both hemispheres comes through constant development and stimulation. The good news however is that all people can be **bilaterial**, engaging both brain hemispheres simultaneously provided people are exposed to brain-based development interventions and brain integrated techniques and activities. Using both the left and right brain hemispheres will enable you to work faster and smarter and therefore make learning easier.

The level of brain fitness is a very important aspect impacting the performance of rugby players, because utilising both brain hemispheres simultaneously will be a vital pre-requisite to out-think, out-wit, out-learn, out-create and out-play their competition on the rugby field according to Vermeulen (2005). Research indicates that the brain can become unfit in a period of as short as five days without any stimulation. According to Rugby News Annual (2005), players who study or practice other professional careers perform better than professional rugby players who do nothing else. "It is clear that new challenges and brain-based stimulation grows balanced rugby players who perform better on the sports field" Vermeulen (2005).

Brain Profiling:
Brain profiling predicts where our mental and physical strengths and weaknesses lie and, most importantly, how we will function under stress. According to Colquhoun (2007), we are genetically programmed at conception to have five dominant sensory perceptions: Brain hemisphere, eye, ear, hand and foot. This is why we instinctively favour one hand over the other or step on or off with a certain foot. It is the same with our eyes and ears; we're either **left-brain dominant** (predisposed to routine and structure) or **right-brain dominant** (bored by repetition). The scary thing is that one can actually find out which players have big match temperament and who don't.

Genetic brain profiling plays an important role in predicting what happens to a player when he gets tired and put under pressure. According to Lotter, "in simple terms, what happens when we're under stress or tired is that we begin to lose access to the non-dominant hemisphere and the modalities functioning from it". It is further stated that

if this stress intensifies we start to see the same loss in the dominant hemisphere. For example, if it is the **right hemisphere**, the ability to plan and forward think would be impaired, and if it is in the **left hemisphere**, the ability to perform repetitive functions would suffer.
Right-brain players might be best suited for the decision-making positions whereas those positions with more repetitive techniques may be better suited to **left-brain** dominances according to Lotter.



<u>Warming up the brain</u>:
As much as the body has to be warmed up to ensure peak physical performance, so the brain should be "switched on" and warmed up if a rugby player wants to out-play the opposition according to Rugby News Annual (2005). This is mandatory, but something that is very seldomly done by sports teams, because they do not know how to switch on the brain, how to activate their senses and how to switch on their neurological system for peak performance.

When a rugby player experiences too much stress, he may secrete inhibiting chemicals like **cortisol** and **morphine** that slow down electrical transmission between brain cells and may even shut down certain areas of the brain according to Rugby News Annual 2005. Vermeulen (2005), states that this is why many rugby players make stereo type mistakes under stress.

The good news is that many physical and mental actions can be taken to ensure that rugby players do not "switch off" certain brain areas under pressure. Players need to stay in the "zone" where they can optimise their brain power, concentration and physical performance.

When a rugby player thinks **negative thoughts** and experiences negative emotions he will secrete more inhibiting chemicals like **cortisol**, which will inhibit and slow down electrical transmissions between cells according to Rugby News Annual (2005). This will have a direct impact on the rugby players' performance resulting in him making mistakes or wrong tactical decisions. These inhibitors also weaken the immune system, drain energy levels, thus leading to ill health and bad physical performance.

If a player thinks **positive thoughts** and experiences constructive emotions he will secrete facilitating chemicals like **seratonin** and **endorphins** that will transmit electrical messages between cells, strengthening their immune system, enhancing mental activity and increasing their performance. All rugby players should be equipped with mental re-patterning skills to ensure that they replace negative mindsets with positive ones according to Rugby News Annual (2005). To help ensure the success of a team the players must have confidence and a constructive approach.

Getting in the Zone:
The brain goes into different states. Every brain state has a different function. When a rugby player runs onto the field, it does not mean that his brain will just automatically be in the right state for peak performance, if he did not take action to activate the desired brain state according to Rugby News Annual (2005). The ideal brain state is a state of relaxed alertness, a state where he can think and perform well. According to Rugby News Annual (2005) this is referred to being in the "zone" where rugby players can be focussed, highly motivated and think on their feet well without stress letting them lose control.

One of the most powerful terms in world sport today is the mental state called "the zone" according to Townsend, C. (2007). This is the mental state that produces super-human performances, amazing times and winning streaks. "An unusual feeling of effortless power, allowing them to feel as if their body is powered by a turbo-charged engine, and they find their body moving with maximum result but minimum energy" Townsend (2007). When an athlete reaches this state they often feel that they are not controlling it themselves and that they are not responsible for the performance. A common question by an athlete would be "how did I do that?" So, what exactly is it? This powerful force which guides the body during this period comes from the subconscious mind. The source of all our bodily movement and past sporting memories and experience come from our subconscious.

When a player is in the "zone" their conscious mind becomes quiet and this allows the more powerful subconscious mind to take over. The athlete is then in "automatic pilot", in the way a computer runs software. This allows their movements to flow much easier, effortlessly increasing speed and power in a way that could never be matched by the conscious thought. "This means that when you in the zone, you have virtually no thought going through your mind whatsoever, your body is just moving on instinct and automatic-pilot, powered by your subconscious mind" Townsend (2007).

Every person is unique and they have their own unique way of getting into the zone. Being in the "zone" is a state of where you are focused, relaxed, and self-trusting according to Rana, S (2007). The superego referred to as the "inner voice" prevents you from getting into the "zone" because it works on you by making you doubt anything and everything and in turn reducing your self-worth. Rana (2007) states that to get into the "zone" you have to shut off the Critical Advisor (super ego) which has a critical mentality. In a team sport like rugby the player needs to learn to forget about the result, but focus more on their own performance. A person in the "zone" only

focuses on the present and will not allow any negative emotions from the past or future effect their performance.

Unique brain-based strengths:
Rugby players also need to know what their unique brain-based strengths and talents are. According to Rugby News Annual (2005) there are four categories of intelligence and eleven different forms of intelligence. All people are smart but, in different ways. If a player knows how he is smart it will help him outplay the opposition.

A good captain should have strong **emotional intelligence** which implies that he can control himself well under pressure and will still be able to healthily interact with team mates and make smart decisions on the field. Also being strong language smart will contribute to increased effectiveness of communication on the sports field according to Rugby News Annual (2005).

A "game breaker" will have strong **creative intelligence** as this capacity will enable him to make a quick strategic analysis of the game and take actions to out-wit his opposition. Creative intelligence is normally a prerequisite for back line players and some loose forwards according to Rugby Annual News (2005).

People become successful at what they do when they primarily focus on enhancing and utilising their strengths. Knowing one's strengths will give you an indication of the gifts and talents you have to be able to out-play the competition.

If a player is **right brain dominant** it would make that person a conceptual and strategic thinker on the field. This player would be able to grasp the bigger picture of the situation on the field at once, making a creative decision on how to out-play their opponents. The right brain dominant player will also see links between other sports and rugby.

Another area to look at is the players **learning receptivity**. If this is high the player will learn from other people and experiences easily, be mentally flexible to change, and adapt easily to new situations like rules that change or new environments.

If a player is **logical / mathematical intelligent** they will focus on acquiring and practicing the specific techniques required for their position and analyse the details of the technique.

A strong **visual / spatial intelligence** allows a player to use the space that he has on the field more creatively because they can picture and use the space instantly.

Strong **intrapersonal intelligence** makes a player accurately aware of his own strengths and weaknesses and allows him to manage himself well. A player with this strength will not lose focus easily or be easily intimidated.

Some players may also show a strong preference for **physical intelligence**, which implies that they enjoy acquiring and executing physical skills.

Strong **spiritual intelligence** will make a player very purpose driven and passionate.

Linguistic intelligence allows a player to efficiently and clearly communicate with his players.

A player who shows a greater **intrapersonal (self) intelligence** may be more individualistic than a player who shows a greater **interpersonal (people) intelligence**. A player with stronger interpersonal intelligence will be a far better team player.

Having poor **musical intelligence** may cause a player to lose rhythm when under pressure. For example a hooker or kicker may lose rhythm under pressure if his musical intelligence was poor.

Conclusion:
Everyone is unique and has been genetically programmed to react to different situations in their own way, in order to reach their full potential. There is substantial evidence from this article that your performance will increase from knowing who you are and what your strengths or weaknesses are. If the individual in a team can learn how to reach their optimal performance level, collectively the team's performance will be unrivalled by a team who has not been able to. Get rid of that "inner voice" let your subconscious take control and get into the "zone"!

References:

Colquhoun, A. (2007). GENETIC IMPERATIVES. Popular Mechanics, September 2007.

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Vermeulen, A. (2005). BRAIN POWER. Rugby News Annual 2005.

MULTIPLE INTELLIGENCES:

Some of the ways of exploring and solving problems listed in this study may feel uncomfortable to you while others seem comfortable. That's because you do have a preferred, personal learning style. Everyone in the team has their own strengths. This is why it is important to know what they are. Some players may be suited to specific positions more than others. This is the aim of this exercise.

Think of these intelligences as members of your team, various approaches will be most suitable in specific areas. Look to maximise your team's performance by being open to various intelligences.

Here is a brief summary of some of the different types of intelligences:

1. **LINGUISTIC**: Good with language; can debate effectively; able to write easily; avid reader… A good captain in a rugby team should score high in this intelligence. **Linguistic intelligence** allows a player to efficiently and clearly communicate with his players.
2. **MATHEMATICAL LOGIC**: Effective in describing patterns; can generate mathematical formulae; able to design / conduct an experiment… If a player is **logical / mathematical intelligent** they will focus on acquiring and practicing the specific techniques required for their position and analyse the details of the technique.
3. **BODILY / PHYSICAL**: Enjoy building / constructing; enjoy hands-on opportunities; enjoy the outdoors… Some players may also show a strong preference for **physical intelligence**, which implies that they enjoy acquiring and executing physical skills.
4. **VISUAL / SPATIAL**: Invent board games; can draw illustrate, sketch etc.; able to use a map effectively; effectively use maps, graphs, diagrams… A strong **visual / spatial intelligence** allows a player to use the space that he has on the field more creatively because they can picture and use the space instantly.
5. **MUSICAL**: Naturally pick up rhythms; enjoy whistling / singing; enjoy explaining how song is made up with various instruments…If this is poor it may cause a player to lose rhythm when under pressure e.g. a hooker or kicker.
6. **INTER-PERSONAL**: Gifted with social skills; able to impart your knowledge; able to conduct meetings / discussions; socially gregarious…A player with stronger **interpersonal (people) intelligence** will be a far better team player.
7. **INTRA-PERSONAL**: Able to describe your strengths, set & pursue a goal; describe your personal values… Strong **intrapersonal (self) intelligence** makes a player accurately aware of his own strengths and weaknesses and allows him to manage himself well. A player with this strength will not lose focus easily or be easily intimidated.
8. **NATURALIST**: Cares for pets, insects…; use microscopes, telescopes…; notice the natural environment; keen observation skills…

Multiple Intelligence Self Inventory

Read the statements listed below. Decide how strongly you agree / disagree that each statement best represents you. Use the scale:

1 = strongly disagree 2 = disagree 3 = uncertain 4 = agree 5 = strongly agree

1	Books are important to me.	1	2	3	4	5
2	I can easily compute numbers in my head.	1	2	3	4	5
3	I am sensitive to colour.	1	2	3	4	5
4	I engage in at least one sport or physical activity on a regular basis.	1	2	3	4	5
5	I have a pleasant singing voice.	1	2	3	4	5
6	I am the sort of person people come to for advice and counsel.	1	2	3	4	5
7	I regularly spend time alone meditating, reflecting or thinking about important life questions.	1	2	3	4	5
8	I enjoy being outdoors.	1	2	3	4	5
9	When I drive on the freeway, I pay attention to the words on the advertising boards than the scenery.	1	2	3	4	5
10	I enjoy playing games or solving brain teasers that require logical thinking.	1	2	3	4	5
11	I prefer looking at reading material that is heavily illustrated.	1	2	3	4	5
12	I find it difficult to sit still for long periods of time.	1	2	3	4	5
13	I know the tunes to many different songs or musical pieces.	1	2	3	4	5
14	I consider myself as a leader.	1	2	3	4	5
15	I am able to respond to setbacks with resilience.	1	2	3	4	5
16	I enjoy classifying rocks or plants or animals.	1	2	3	4	5
17	I enjoy word games like Scrabble and cross-words.	1	2	3	4	5
18	I believe that almost everything has a rational explanation.	1	2	3	4	5
19	I have vivid dreams at night.	1	2	3	4	5
20	I can mimic and imitate others well.	1	2	3	4	5
21	I ‘hear’ melodies, rhythms and harmonies in my mind.	1	2	3	4	5
22	I would rather spend my evenings at a lively party than stay at home alone.	1	2	3	4	5
23	I have a special hobby or interest that pretty much keeps me to myself.	1	2	3	4	5
24	I accept the effectiveness of homeopathy.	1	2	3	4	5
25	My conversation includes frequent reference to things that I have read or heard.	1	2	3	4	5
26	I like finding logical flaws in things that people say and do at home and work.	1	2	3	4	5
27	I like to draw or doodle.	1	2	3	4	5
28	I need to touch things in order to learn more about them.	1	2	3	4	5
29	I can tell when a musical note is off-key.	1	2	3	4	5
30	I touch others while talking to them.	1	2	3	4	5
31	I consider myself to be strong-willed or independent minded.	1	2	3	4	5
32	I look for patterns in nature.	1	2	3	4	5
33	I can persuade and convince others with words.	1	2	3	4	5
34	I feel content when testing hypotheses using measurements.	1	2	3	4	5
35	I can ‘picture’ where all the furniture will fit in a new place.	1	2	3	4	5
36	I would describe myself as well co-ordinated.	1	2	3	4	5
37	I often make tapping sounds or sing little melodies while working.	1	2	3	4	5
38	I enjoy performing tasks with other people.	1	2	3	4	5
39	I can detect and express complex feelings in myself.	1	2	3	4	5
40	I am fascinated by the weather.	1	2	3	4	5

Self Inventory – Score Sheet

	L	ML	VS	BP	M	Inter	Intra	N
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16
	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
	25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32
	33	34	35	36	37	38	39	40
Totals:								

These intelligences can be used as a guideline for position specific characteristics. A coach could use this test to help him make a decision on which player to select.

MIND OVER MATTER

For many years, sports physiologists were convinced that no-one could run a mile in less than four minutes. However, a talented runner, Roger Bannister, was determined to prove them wrong. He trained his body so that he could run his fastest—but he also trained his mind, focusing on the idea that he could break the four-minute barrier. On 6 May, 1954, he did just that. Once Bannister had shown that the four-minute barrier could be broken, other runners found that they could break it too. The barrier had been as much a mental as a physical one. The following year more than 300 runners ran the mile in under four minutes.

This story illustrates the power that the mind has over the body. Bannister could not have run the four-minute mile without rigorous physical training, but he also needed to believe that he could do it. Today it is recognized that having a positive mental attitude gives top sports men and women the winning edge over competitors with equal physical skills, and many competitors practice relaxation and visualization techniques before competing.

Believing that you can do something is important in many fields other than sports. For people in all walks of life and all states of physical fitness, the mind has a powerful impact on the body.

Healthy mind, healthy body

In one study reported in the influential British medical journal, *The Lancet*, Dr. Carlton Evans of St. Thomas's Hospital, London found that patients who were exposed to a positive suggestion while they were anaesthetized had a better recovery than another group not given the suggestion. While on the operating table, one group of patients were given suggestions such as: "You will want to get up and get out of bed to help your body recover earlier." After their operations, they did just that and had fewer post-operative complications and a speedier recovery.

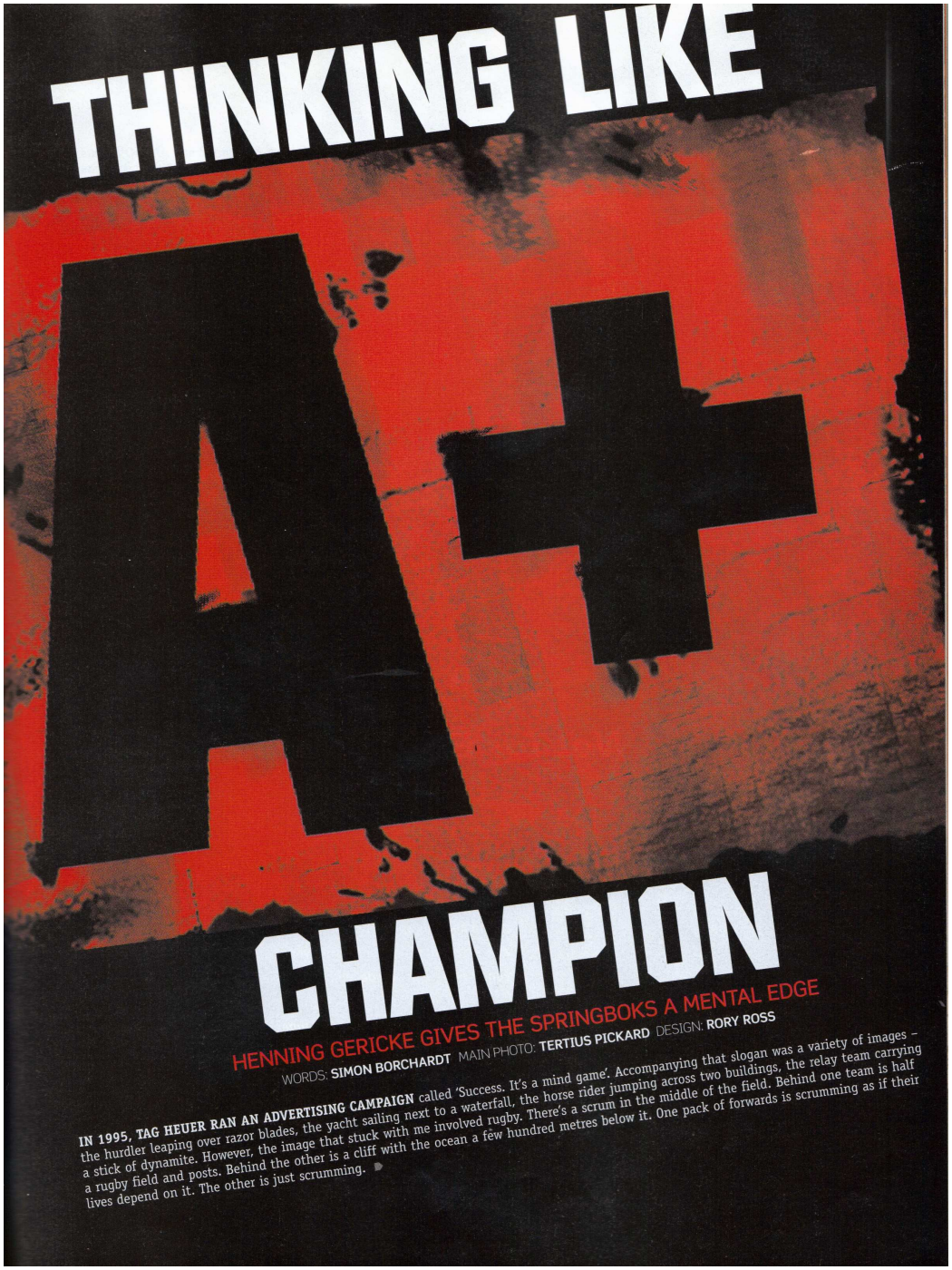
However, although people told that they are getting better often do better, those told that they are ill often get worse.



Believing in himself
Roger Bannister trained his mind as well as his body in order to break the four-minute-mile barrier.

Reference:

Mind Power, **Maximise your Performance**. Time-Life Books, Europe Edition (1995).



<u>Reference</u>:

Borchart, S. (2007). THINKING LIKE A+ CHAMPION. SA Rugby Magazine (2007)

Henning Gericke, the Springboks mental and speed coach, firmly believes success is a mind game. He has a doctorate in psychology and has broken new ground in the field of mental coaching. When he was an elite athlete, he ran 10 sub-four-minute miles – a feat that requires great physical and mental strength.

When Gericke joined the Boks in 2004, the beginning of the Jake White era, he found a group of players still carrying mental scars from the Rudolf Straeuli regime. The first thing he did to repair the damage was to create a family environment, where players care for each other. Unlike Straeuli, he also got the players' families involved wherever possible.

Gericke then set about restoring the Boks' focus on the game. Over the last four years, he has held weekly sessions with the squad and regularly meets each player on an individual basis.

'In our weekly group sessions, I look at the mental challenges that we face in the upcoming Test,' he tells *SA Rugby* magazine. 'For example, we may need to be aggressive but relaxed enough to make good decisions on the field. We may have a poor record at the stadium at which we're going to play and need to make that negative mindset positive.

'The individual sessions are equally important,' he adds. 'Every player is different mentally, so I find out what motivates each one. Where does he get his inner strength? Where does he get his calmness? Where does he get his focus? What's the best mental frame I can put him in?'

Gericke's approach to mental training varies according to the needs of the player. 'Someone like JP [Pietersen] needs to feel confident and needs constant encouragement to help build and maintain that confidence,' he says. 'Despite playing 70-plus Tests, Os [du Randt] always feels the need to prove himself and show his team-mates he deserves to be in the squad. Os needs to set goals. He always wants to challenge himself and get better. Butch [James], on the other hand, plays by the three Cs – cool, calm and confident. When he was too aggressive in the past, his decision-making suffered, so the three Cs remind him of the way he wants to play. Basically, you have to find the right mental triggers to get the player into the zone that works for him.'

Few of us who admit being average sportsmen have ever been in the zone. Perhaps we entered it briefly by scoring a try or hitting a six at school or club level, but we haven't stayed there for long. The best in the business not only play in the zone for lengthy periods, they know how to get there regularly.

'The zone is a state of being when things just happen for a player,' explains Gericke. 'You feel you're always in the right place at the right time. You make the right decisions. You don't overanalyse your game. When you are in the zone, the mind trusts the body and the body trusts the mind. You enjoy the here and now, you don't worry about the outcome. The zone is a state of mind where you're calm, relaxed and focused.'

One Springbok who has successfully entered the zone this season is Frans Steyn. Having taken massive flak for missing a conversion that would have won the Sharks the Super 14 final and then failing to find touch after the hooter, the 20-year-old made amends against the Wallabies at Newlands. Steyn came off the bench in the final quarter when the Boks were trailing 19-16. The replacement winger levelled the scores with an ambitious drop goal from the right-hand touchline and then won the game with another from an easier position a few minutes from full time. When asked afterwards what had gone through his mind Steyn said, 'Er, nothing. I trusted my instincts.'

'Frans's answer sums up what it's like to be in the zone,' Gericke says. 'People probably weren't expecting a lot from him that day, because he was a substitute, so he could just come on and play his natural game. Another Bok who I always tell to trust his instincts is André Pretorius. André has a kicking routine that works for him, so I try not to get too involved. Before a game, I'll walk up to him and remind him to back himself on the field. That's all I need to say.'

It's the 2007 World Cup final between the Boks and All Blacks at Stade de France. A Dan Carter penalty has just put New Zealand into a one-point lead with two minutes to go. The Bok restart goes deep and bounces into touch after brushing a Kiwi hand. South Africa have one last chance to win the game, and the Webb Ellis Cup, with a line-out 5m from the opposition tryline. This next passage of play will determine whether the Boks spend the next four years as world champions or wondering what might have been. The pressure is suffocating. Or is it?

'My job is to prepare the players for a situation like that,' says Gericke. 'Obviously, this team has never trailed by a point in a World Cup final before, so we can't draw on previous experience. Instead, we create "what if?" scenarios for the players. What if we are in a situation like the one you've just described? Well, we'd want to keep focused and stick to the basics ... do what we'd do in any other Test match. If that means throwing the ball to Bakkies [Botha], setting up the driving maul and going for the pushover try, then so be it. If that means trying to create space and time for a drop goal attempt, then that's what must be done.'

Gericke says the secret to winning those close battles is in keeping composure. 'We have trigger words to help the Boks achieve this. John [Smit], for example, will yell out a word that will put everybody in the same frame of mind. One word can tell the team to slow the pace down, stick to the basics, focus on the small things, stay cool etc ... It's a case of shared thinking in that every player will know what to do.

'We've been involved in a few close games since 2004. Some we've won, others we've lost, but we've learnt a lot from them all. To win those games you need decision-makers, players in key positions – hooker, flyhalf, fullback etc – who can handle the pressure. We have those players.' ▶



Gericke insists the Boks would not choke in a World Cup final.

PHOTO: TERTIUS PICKARD/GALLO IMAGES

Chokers. It's a word that sticks to sports teams and individuals who crack under pressure and lose matches they should have won. In the 1993 Wimbledon women's singles final, Jana Novotna led Steffi Graf 4-1 in the deciding third set and was up 40-15 on her serve. Then the Czechoslovakian lost her nerve, missing simple shots, including an overhead smash that hit the back tarp. Graf won the next five games and a shattered Novotna cried on the Duchess of Kent's shoulder.

In the 1999 Cricket World Cup semi-finals, South Africa needed one run off four balls with one wicket in hand. Lance Klusener, whose big hitting had brought the Proteas back from the dead, called for a quick single. Allan Donald, at the other end, hesitated, dropped his bat and was run out. The match was tied but Australia progressed to the final on a superior run rate.

As far as the Rugby World Cup is concerned, the All Blacks were the best team in 1995 but lost to the Boks in the final. They were red-hot favourites in 1999 but self-imploded against France in the semi-finals. It was a similar case in 2003, when they gifted the Wallabies an intercept try in the semi-finals and went on to lose a match most expected them to win quite comfortably.

'Choking does happen in sport,' says Gericke. 'It comes from high and sometimes unrealistic expectations. The All Blacks, for example, are under huge pressure to win the World Cup this year. Their fans demand it. Their media demand it. Hell, the whole country demands it.'

When delving into the choking phenomenon, Gericke uses an example not listed above. 'I believe a team that is mentally strong will not allow choking to happen. They will take control of the situation. Look at our cricket team at the World Cup this year. A lot of people had a lot to say about them, and they responded by changing their tactics for the semi-final against Australia. They came out attacking Australia's bowlers, taking crazy risks, and lost five wickets for 27 runs. That shows me they weren't in control of what they wanted to do.'

Gericke insists the Boks will not allow outside pressure to change their approach to the game. 'We won't choke at the World Cup because we have a core of experienced players and good, strong leadership. I know our guys will keep their cool, stay focused and do what has worked for them in the past.'

Some players have big-match temperament, some don't. Some players thrive under pressure, some don't.

'Players who have BMT have often been in a pressurised situation before and been successful,' says Gericke. 'That builds confidence and they believe they'll be able to succeed again if they find themselves in a similar situation. Other players have crumbled under the pressure, so when they're under pressure again, they doubt themselves and have negative thoughts. And if your mind's not right, you won't have BMT.'

Whereas Gericke insists everyone who reaches Bok level has BMT, he admits he does have to calm a player down every now and then. 'It's all about anxiety and confidence; you need to get the balance right. If you worry too much, your confidence will go down, but if you don't worry at all and you're overconfident, then you're asking for trouble.

'Self-awareness is crucial in order to have BMT. You must be aware of what works for you. If you can do that, you will be in control of all situations. There will be times when you make mistakes, and you have to know how to calm yourself down and refocus.'

Gericke constantly reminds his players that the way they think about themselves affects how they play.

'We talk about the Law of Attraction, which states you attract what you think. People who think like champions are successful. People often aim not to fail instead of aiming to succeed. They've always been told "Don't do this, don't do that", so they can't be creative and true to themselves. The Springboks are going to think like champions at the World Cup and play like champions. I can promise you that.'

We're nearing the end of our interview when Jake White walks past looking worried. I ask Gericke whether he ever has mental-training sessions with the Bok coach, who is often under more pressure than his players.

'Jake does take strain, so we'll meet two or three times a week and chat about things,' he says. 'It's very informal, perhaps over a couple of drinks. I try to focus his thoughts, and we'll discuss the pressure he's under. He'll go to gym in the morning, so he has his way of dealing with it, and every now and then I'll give him something to read that I think may help him. Sometimes he'll ask me about a player and I'll tell him what I think.

'Mentally, Jake is incredibly focused on winning the World Cup. He knows he's entering the final straight of his Bok coaching career and he can't be sacked.'

Gericke also has a special relationship with the captain. 'John will come up to me and discuss what the team needs and what certain individuals need, so I'm always aware of the vibe in the squad. For example, we arranged a team-building exercise in Durban before the World Cup where the players went on a 10km walk. Along the route there were places to stop and at each place they had to discuss a previous Bok World Cup campaign. At the end of the walk, they arrived at John's house, where every player had a person waiting for them who is an important part of their life. The team gets extra energy from things like that.'

I shake hands with Gericke and am walking away when he calls me back. 'You know, I honestly believe we can win the World Cup. The players believe it too.' From the look in his eyes, I can see there's no doubt in his mind.



Os du Randt always feels the need to prove himself.

PHOTO: LEE WARREN/GALLO IMAGES

RUGBY BRAIN PROFILE:

Name	Surname	Team	Position 1	Position 2	Position 3

In the next section we are going to determine the unique thought preferences that formed you as rugby player by determining your rugby brain profile. It is an important starting-point because if you are able to understand your own brain preference, you will not only obtain insight into your own behaviour, but also into that of your team-mates which may differ a great deal from yours.

It is very important not to rush through this section and to read the questions carefully and answer them in total honesty. **Remember, there are no right or wrong answers. Everybody eventually ends with a grant total of 150. Therefore, although our profiles differ which indicates our uniqueness, it has nothing to do with right or wrong, good or bad. When working through the questionnaire, remember the following:**

- Read every question closely and react according to your preference (not as you think others want you to react).
- Allocate your marks accurately every time.
- When you have answered all the questions, write down the marks accurately on the score-card at the end of the specific section.
- Add the marks in each column carefully (there are 4 columns) and to make sure that you have added correctly, add your four totals at the end of each column.

  The four totals must give you a grand total of 150.
- Now make a dot on the circle, more or less where your mark must be and link the dots. (There is a completed example to help you drawing the profile.)
- Do not rush! There is no time limit – enjoy it!

Now determine your own rugby brain profile

Allocate marks at every question as follows:

- 4 for your first choice
- 3 for your second choice
- 2 for your third choice
- 1 for your last choice

Fill your choice into the block next to the question. After completing the questionnaire, fill in your marks on the score-card at the end of the questionnaire.

1. If I think about a rugby match that I must play I prefer to ...
   a. develop a positive attitude about the match ☐
   b. think very specifically about the match ☐
   c. think of the match in general ☐
   d. remember the plans for the match that we have practised ☐

2. I prefer a captain who ...
   a. is realistic and objective ☐
   b. wants to listen ☐
   c. has an open mind ☐
   d. is well-organised ☐

3. I prefer team situations ...
   a. that are friendly and relaxed ☐
   b. where advanced skills are appreciated ☐
   c. that are exciting and not always the same ☐
   d. where everybody is well-prepared ☐

4. If the coach discusses tactics for the match with the team, I prefer him to ...
   a. do it in a focussed manner without flippancy ☐
   b. do it quickly so that we can get to the field ☐
   c. do it systematically, step by step ☐
   d. make the team members part of the discussion ☐

5. I prefer a coach who ...
   a. plans efficiently ☐
   b. focusses strongly on team spirit ☐
   c. exchanges ideas freely ☐
   d. can analyse the match well ☐

6. If I change to another club (province, school, etc.) I will ...
   a. objectively study and analyse the advantages of the change ☐
   b. try to determine how the change fits into my future rugby plans ☐
   c. wonder how I will fit in with my new team-mates ☐
   d. wonder how the change will influence my familiar circumstances ☐

7. While practising on the field, I prefer ...
   a. to practise in a relaxed atmosphere ☐
   b. to practise the movements in a dedicated manner ☐
   c. to get clearly formulated instructions ☐
   d. many variations in the training programme ☐

8. I prefer my team-mates to describe me as somebody who ...
   a. does not say unpleasant things about them ☐
   b. speaks plainly ☐
   c. practises with dedication and diligence ☐
   d. always makes plans on the field ☐

9. I prefer the game tactics to be ...
   a. analysed thoroughly ☐
   b. applied unchanged during the match ☐
   c. discussed by al the team members ☐
   d. only a starting-point that leaves room for deviation ☐

10. I enjoy the company of team-mates who ...
   a. know what they want ☐
   b. are imaginative and always try new things ☐
   c. are punctual and do not make their team-mates wait ☐
   d. are friendly and easy-going ☐

11. If I play in a match, I prefer ...
   a. that we will make no mistakes ☐
   b. the team spirit to be very positive ☐
   c. that we stick to the plan for the match ☐
   d. to do things on the spur of the moment ☐

12. In the change-room before the match, I prefer to ...
   a. summon my passion for the match ☐
   b. concentrate on the match without being disturbed ☐
   c. go over the match in my mind for the last time ☐
   d. wait in a relaxed mood for the beginning of the match ☐

13. When the ball is kicked directly at me, my first reaction is to ...
   a. start playing according to a practised movement ☐
   b. look for support ☐
   c. start with a counter-attack ☐
   d. keep my focus ☐

14. As a new member of the team, I will give preference to ...
   a. a well-organised rugby environment ☐
   b. acceptance by the players and coaches ☐
   c. very specific guidelines about what is expected of me ☐
   d. opportunities ☐

15. When I play rugby ...
   a. I am constantly on the lookout for new possibilities and options ☐
   b. I am calculated and do not allow my feelings to play a role ☐
   c. I am always thoroughly prepared ☐
   d. I am a team player and not an individual ☐

Completion of your profile score-card

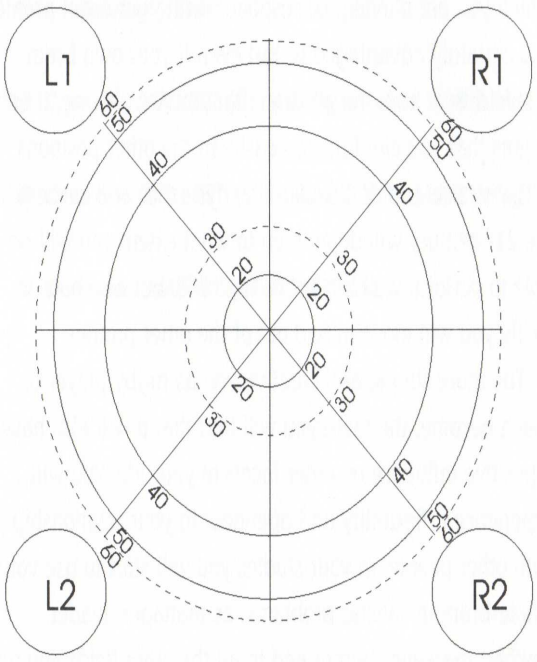
It may appear time consuming but it is important to complete the following score-card very accurately. Note that the a, b, c and d do not appear at the same place every time.

- Write down the marks that you have allocated for every question accurately and then add up every column separately.
- When you add up your FOUR totals at the bottom of the page, your grand total must be 150.

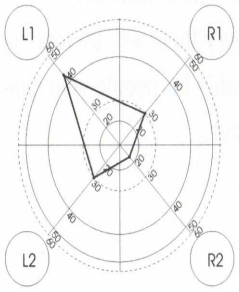
1	b	d	a	c	
2	a	d	b	c	
3	b	d	a	c	
4	a	c	d	b	
5	d	a	b	c	
6	a	d	c	b	
7	c	b	a	d	
8	b	c	a	d	
9	a	b	c	d	
10	a	c	d	b	
11	a	c	b	d	
12	b	c	a	d	
13	d	a	b	c	
14	c	a	b	d	
15	b	c	d	a	
TOTAL					= 150
	L1	L2	R2	R1	

Now fill in your totals in the small circles and then make a dot more or less where your score lies. Then link the dots

to determine your parent brain profile. (Take a look at the example below if you experience any problems.)



Example



BRAIN PROFILE:

L1: Left Quadrant (Top Left) **Logic:**
Focus
Think Logically
Dedicated and focused
Think concretely and rationally and to utilise specific knowledge in the process
To operate from memory
To make logical conclusions
To act in line with definite training methods

R1: Right Quadrant (Top Right) **Creativity:**
Individualism
Imagination
Being different
Renewal
Unusualness
Intuition
Looking at the big picture
Experimenting and acting on the spur of the moment

L2: Left Quadrant (Bottom Left) **Systematic Approach:**
Preference for systematic, step by step approach
Discipline and order
Learnt patterns
Rules and regulations
Systematic approach
Thorough planning

R2: Right Quadrant (Bottom Right) **Emotional Intelligence:**
Group cohesion
Teamwork
Unity
Mutual support
Strong passion
The development of feeling and emotion
Communication and interaction

Reference:

Botha, N. and Neethling, K. (1999). CREATIVE RUGBY, Don't just sweat it, think it! Carpe diem. First Edition.